

film reviews

Failure to Launch

KISMAT KONNECTION

Director: Aziz Mirza
Starring: Shahid Kapur,
Vidya Balan

A hero named Raj Malhotra, standing with his arms outstretched in the middle of a foreign street, his hair being blown by a personal fan? Remind you of something? Yup. Countless movies featuring Shah Rukh Khan, some of them directed by Aziz Mirza. The veteran director is back trying to recreate the schmaltzy middle class magic of *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman* and *Yes Boss*. But the plot is worn out and Shahid Kapur tries too hard to look lovestruck while also displaying his impressive cleavage. The story of a loser willing to stake everything to suc-



TOOTHsome TWOSOME: Kapur and Balan try too hard

ceed (including the future of homeless old people and the woman he loves) but having a change of heart at the last minute has a kinda-sorta tired feel to it. The gloss of a foreign location—the film was shot almost entirely in Toronto—does not help. Style does not meet substance. There are too many songs that

seem like leftovers from Pritam's score for another Kapur film, *Jab We Met*, and some of them need translation from Punjabi. In the end you feel like one of the characters, Himani Shivpuri, whose stock line to her loud Punjabi husband is a zinger: Lower your tone, please.

by Kaveer Banzal

Silent Killer

CONTRACT

Director: Ram Gopal Varma
Starring: Adhvik Mahajan,
Sakshi Gulati

A shirtless exercise routine by the beach, where the sweat glistens on the star's back. Ooh! Antara Mali in *Naach*? No. This is Ram Gopal Varma, so it's a new muse every Friday. This time it's a boy (Adhvik Mahajan). And the best thing that one can say about him is that he has nice teeth. These he bares on every occasion that some histrionics are called for. They are quite often in Varma's descent into Mumbai's underworld again, this time to trace its link with terrorism. As an



THE EYES HAVE IT: Mahajan's tryst with the underworld

academic exercise it is a good idea. But there's not much new for those who have watched Varma—and his clones—explore every facet of the Dawood Ibrahim-Chhota Rajan rivalry. As is his wont, though, Varma discovers yet another fringe actor

we will see more of—Prasad Purandare. But don't go looking for anything more than a handful of nice lines 'jab sar katne wala ho, toh shave ki kya zaroorat?' (Why shave when you are about to lose your head?) Is Varma talking about himself? —K.B.

music reviews

Worldly Charms



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THE INDIAN CORE

Jazz coupled with Indian classical music is truly in-

trinsic. The Norwegian jazz group, The Core, collaborate with Indian musicians like Kanchan Babbar (on the flute), Fateh Ali (on sitar) and Prasennjit Mitra (on tabla). Elements of Indian classical music and jazz have been intertwined creatively, incorporating the saxophone, flute, sitar, double bass, piano and tabla. The Core came to India to work with Mitra, Babbar and Ali, and within a week, they had created sufficient material for an extensive tour of Norway. The outcome of this album clearly captures the best of both worlds.



Music Today
Rs 299

SNAKE CHARMER

Remember when we were children, we used to be fascinated

by snake charmers and the musical instrument which will forever relate us to them—the been's sound is resonant and piercing and is also commonly used in most Indian ragas. It has been popularised by films such as *Naagin* and *Nagina*. In the series of *Amazing India*, this album is unique because it captures the many melodies played on this ancient folk instrument. The music has been arranged by Upmanyu Bhanot, a two-album-old musician. Explore the different faces of snake charmers and their mesmerising music.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit